

Duke funding and startup support

For SimReal (Duke co-founder: Amaris) · built 2026-10-04 · public information only

121

programs and resources

15

high fit, SimReal
qualifies, open or
upcoming

47

named contacts

8

with a published email

- **Qualifies** means our reading of the published rules for a startup with a current Duke undergraduate as co-founder. Check each program's latest terms before applying.
- **Status** is as of 2026-10-04. Deadlines change every cycle; "rolling" means applications are taken year-round.
- **Contacts** are listed only when the organization or the person published them. Emails were never guessed or taken from data-broker sites.

Key dates

Date	Program	Note	Who applies
Oct 4, 2026	PearX W27	Regular deadline per a third-party listing (today). Teams relocate to the Bay Area.	SimReal
Oct 8, 2026	America's Startup (America250)	Up to \$50K non-dilutive. Entrants must be US legal residents and current US undergrads, so it rests on Amaris.	Amaris
Oct 12 - Nov 1, 2026	a16z speedrun SR008	Reported priority window; rolling after. Cohort late Jan-Apr 2027 in SF.	SimReal
Nov 2, 2026	Y Combinator W27	\$500K. Early Decision lets a student founder finish the term first.	SimReal
Nov 4, 2026	NSF SBIR Phase I	Up to \$305K, but needs a US company more than 50% owned by US citizens or permanent residents.	SimReal (if eligible)
Jan 2027	Duke Startup Showcase	Applications open in January; finals Apr 8, 2027. Over \$110K in prizes in 2026; needs one current Duke student founder.	Amaris
Jan 8, 2027	Microsoft Imagine Cup	All team members must be enrolled students.	Students only
Jan 30, 2027	ACC InVenture Prize	\$15K first prize. One team per ACC school; undergrads only; under \$100K raised.	Amaris
~Late Feb 2027	NC IDEA SEED	\$50K grant; needs NC headquarters and founders living in NC.	SimReal (if NC-based)
Mar 23-24, 2027	CED Venture Connect	Durham investor conference with a software pitch track; applications likely open late 2026 or January.	SimReal

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Program	What you get	Timing
Duke I&E founder advising hub (Startup Fest, Founders Weekend, staff advising) Duke I&E	Duke's central front door for student founders.	Ongoing.

John Shen Duke Startup Showcase (successor to the Duke Startup Challenge) Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship (Duke I&E)	Live pitch competition for more than \$110,000 in non-dilutive prize money (2026: two \$30,000 grand prizes, one for the top undergraduate-led venture...	2026 cycle: applications due Jan 19;
Duke Capital Partners (formerly Duke Angel Network) Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022)	Equity investment from Duke's official early-stage venture arm.	Deal review is on a rolling basis.
Frank Borchardt Undergraduate Prize Fund Duke I&E (gift of Duke alum David Cummings)	\$20,000 in grant money each year for the top undergraduate entrepreneurs at Duke.	Awarded at the spring Showcase (Apr 9 in 2026).
Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs Duke I&E (sponsored by Melissa Bernstein '87 and Doug Bernstein)	Duke's premier year-long accelerator and leadership program for student founders (9 months, Aug-Apr, non-credit, in person).	The 2026-27 cohort started with a welcome workshop in August 2026, and applications for it are closed.
Duke I&E regional networking events (NYC Networking Night, other cities) via Duke Alumni events Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship / Duke Alumni Association	In-person networking with Duke alumni and parents who are founders, investors and operators.	Recurring regional events.
Towerview Ventures (Alumni Ventures' Duke fund) Alumni Ventures	Venture investment from Alumni Ventures' fund for Duke alumni and friends.	Rolling.
Dorm Room Fund (Philly & Southeast team covers Duke) Dorm Room Fund (First Round-founded, student-run)	Investment from a student-run VC that backs startups founded by college students and recent graduates in the US and Canada.	Rolling for founders.
American Underground (coworking, community, FCAT Fellowship) American Underground (Durham; Capitol Broadcasting Company)	Durham's long-running startup hub ('Startup Hub of the South').	Coworking is rolling.
Bull City Venture Partners (BCVP) Bull City Venture Partners (Durham)	VC equity.	Rolling.
Cofounders Capital Cofounders Capital (Cary, NC)	Seed equity from Fund III, a \$50M fund for B2B software at seed stage with a special focus on NC.	Rolling.
ACC InVenture Prize 2027 Atlantic Coast Conference (ACC) Academic Consortium; Duke selects its team	Non-dilutive cash prizes: \$15,000 first place, \$10,000 second, \$5,000 People's Choice (\$30,000 total).	Faculty representative application due 23 Jan 2027.
Launch Powered by KPMG accelerator Launch Chapel Hill (Town of Chapel Hill / UNC / KPMG partnership)	An equity-free accelerator that describes itself as AI-enabled.	Cohort 4: applications closed 31 Jul 2026;
Y Combinator (W27, incl. Early Decision for students) Y Combinator	\$500K: \$125K for 7% plus \$375K on a SAFE.	W27 (Jan-Mar 2027, SF) on-time deadline is Nov 2, 2026 at 8pm PT, with decisions by Dec 11.
a16z speedrun (SR008) Andreessen Horowitz	\$500K for 10% on a SAFE upfront, plus \$500K in the next round within 18 months (up to \$1M), and \$5M+ in partner credits.	SR007 ran July 27-Oct 11, 2026.

Duke I&E founder advising hub (Startup Fest, Founders Weekend, staff advising)

SimReal qualifies: yes

open

High fit

Duke I&E · Network / community

- What you get** Duke's central front door for student founders. Duke I&E runs the funding programs above (over \$329,000 in non-dilutive prizes and student-founder support funds in FY25), Startup Fest at the start of each semester, Founders Weekend (for LAUNCH founders) and staff advising. No dedicated 'Entrepreneurship Week' was found in searches.
- Eligibility** Duke students, alumni and community. SimReal: yes through Amaris.
- Timing** Ongoing. Startup Fest is held at the start of each semester.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/startup-support ; email entrepreneurship@duke.edu
- Why it fits** One conversation with I&E staff can route SimReal to the Showcase, Seed Stage Award, LAUNCH, the Bernstein fund and Duke Capital Partners at once.
- Contacts**
Jamie N. Jones, PhD, Director, Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship; Associate Professor of the Practice of Management, Fuqua (former Executive Director, Fuqua CEI), jamie.j@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/jamie-jones
Amy Linnane, Managing Director, Programs (profile page titled 'Managing Director, Co-Curricular Programs'), Duke I&E; runs all co-curricular programming incl. Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs, amy.linnane@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/amy-linnane
Josh Cohen (MBA '07), Director of MBA Entrepreneurship Programs and Startup Recruiting, Duke I&E (runs Startup Sprint, Innovators' Spark, ELN application process)
Duke I&E general inbox, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

John Shen Duke Startup Showcase (successor to the Duke Startup Challenge)

SimReal qualifies: yes

open

High fit

Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship (Duke I&E) · Competition / prize

What you get	Live pitch competition for more than \$110,000 in non-dilutive prize money (2026: two \$30,000 grand prizes, one for the top undergraduate-led venture (Helian, an AI regulatory-QMS startup) and one for the top graduate/professional-led venture (Toilemetry)). GrepBeat put the 2026 prize pool at \$115.5K. Judge feedback in Feb-Mar pitch rounds, an expo table at the April showcase, and visibility with 500+ Duke community members. The Frank Borchardt Undergraduate Prize Fund (\$20K) is awarded at this event (see separate entry). Note: the old 'Duke Startup Challenge' appears only as archive pages; searches for it return the Showcase, which seems to have replaced it (inference, not confirmed by Duke).
Eligibility	Startup, venture or promising idea from any industry and any stage. At least one founder must be a current Duke student. Founders must be able to take part in person from January to April. SimReal qualifies because Amaris (co-founder/COO) is a current Duke undergrad. The pitch would need to be made by her, in person in Durham.
Timing	2026 cycle: applications due Jan 19; live pitch rounds Feb-Mar; finals Apr 9, 2026 (88 applicants, 36 presented). The 2027 cycle is expected to follow the same Jan-Apr pattern, but the 2027 dates have not been published (unconfirmed).
How to apply	entrepreneurship.duke.edu/programs/duke-startup-showcase/duk (apply via Airtable with Duke NetID single sign-on)
Why it fits	Eligibility only needs one Duke student founder, the money is non-dilutive (up to \$30K grand prize plus the \$20K Borchardt undergrad prize), and AI B2B ventures won in 2026.
Duke angle	Amaris, a current Duke undergraduate, makes SimReal eligible. The \$30K top prize is non-dilutive, and the event has an investor and Duke-network audience. Non-dilutive prizes and exposure at a showcase. In 2026 the prize pool was \$110K-\$115.5K. 88 applicants and 35-36 student ventures presented, and the top undergraduate venture (Helian) won a \$30K grand prize. Held at Fuqua.
Contacts	Jamie N. Jones, PhD , Director, Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship; Associate Professor of the Practice of Management, Fuqua (former Executive Director, Fuqua CEI), jamie.j@duke.edu , entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/jamie-jones Amy Linnane , Managing Director, Programs (profile page titled 'Managing Director, Co-Curricular Programs'), Duke I&E; runs all co-curricular programming incl. Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs, amy.linnane@duke.edu , entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/amy-linnane Duke I&E general inbox , Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu , entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Duke Capital Partners (formerly Duke Angel Network)

SimReal qualifies: likely

open

High fit

Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022) · Funding: equity

What you get	Equity investment from Duke's official early-stage venture arm. Average initial investment is \$500K-\$2M in Seed and Series A rounds, and it also syndicates to Duke-affiliated member investors. In 10 years it has backed about 60 startups with a roughly \$105M portfolio. It is industry-agnostic, but avoids long exit cycles and extremely capital-intensive industries.
Eligibility	A founder, executive or board member must be a Duke alum, faculty, staff, student or parent. The company must be raising seed or Series A equity of \$1M-\$20M, or syndicating a later-stage round with an institutional lead. It must be headquartered, legally structured, or have a significant presence in the US. Ideally it has an MVP and early validation (revenue or signed pilots). SimReal: likely, since Amaris is a current Duke student and co-founder. It must confirm a US entity or significant US presence and a raise of at least \$1M.
Timing	Deal review is on a rolling basis.
How to apply	Submit via Seraf from dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/entrepreneurs (an application form is also hosted at www.sparkxyz.io/applications/1177)
Why it fits	It is the only Duke entity that writes seed checks. SimReal meets the Duke-affiliation test through Amaris, and a \$1M+ seed round is in range.
Duke angle	Amaris, a current Duke student, makes SimReal eligible, and DCP members syndicate alongside the fund at seed. Access to an angel platform of 200+ accredited Duke-affiliated investor members (alumni, faculty, parents) and a co-investment fund, the Duke Innovation Fund. Members have invested \$75M+ in 60+ companies, including \$12M+ in FY24. A later snippet reports \$105M across 65+ companies, FY25 investments of \$21.9M across 23 financings, and an average initial investment of \$500K-\$2M. DCP has co-invested with Sequoia, Kleiner Perkins, Google and Amazon. It also runs about 40 student Associates in a 2-year program.
Contacts	Duke Capital Partners inbox , Generic inbox (2812 Erwin Rd Suite 406, Durham NC 27705), dukecapitalpartners@duke.edu , dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/contact-2 Kurt Schmidt , Managing Director, Duke Capital Partners (since 2019), dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/about Daniel Luo , Assistant Director, Duke Capital Partners, dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team Dr. Cary Ritter , Senior Assistant Director, Duke Capital Partners, dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team Dave Neal , Venture Partner, Duke Capital Partners, dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team Stephanie Seghers , Senior Program Coordinator, Duke Capital Partners, dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team

Frank Borchardt Undergraduate Prize Fund

SimReal qualifies: likely

upcoming

High fit

Duke I&E (gift of Duke alum David Cummings) · Competition / prize

- What you get** \$20,000 in grant money each year for the top undergraduate entrepreneurs at Duke. Awarded at the annual Duke Startup Showcase in spring. Non-dilutive.
- Eligibility** Top Duke undergraduate entrepreneurs, selected through the Startup Showcase. SimReal: likely. Amaris is an undergrad founder. It is not confirmed whether a venture whose other co-founders are non-Duke graduates counts as 'undergraduate-led'. The 2026 Showcase split ventures into undergraduate-led and graduate/professional-led tracks.
- Timing** Awarded at the spring Showcase (Apr 9 in 2026). The 2027 date is unconfirmed. Entry is through the Showcase application (Jan 19 deadline in 2026).
- How to apply** Apply to the Duke Startup Showcase: entrepreneurship.duke.edu/programs/duke-startup-showcase/duk
- Why it fits** \$20K non-dilutive for undergrad-led ventures, entered through the same Showcase application.
- Contacts** **Duke I&E general inbox**, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs

SimReal qualifies: likely

upcoming

High fit

Duke I&E (sponsored by Melissa Bernstein '87 and Doug Bernstein) · Accelerator / incubator

- What you get** Duke's premier year-long accelerator and leadership program for student founders (9 months, Aug-Apr, non-credit, in person). Includes a \$5K grant for eligible ventures (Duke I&E funding page), executive coaching, mentorship from Duke alumni, parents and community members, travel experiences, and one-on-one time with sponsor Melissa Bernstein '87. Third-party site UndergradVC reports up to \$10,000 (\$5K initial plus \$5K follow-on); Duke has not confirmed this.
- Eligibility** Current Duke students actively working on a venture. Revenue is not required. Applicants must be in good academic standing and commit to the in-person 9-month program. Highly selective: up to 15 interviewed for about 10 spots. SimReal: likely. The program admits the student founder (Amaris), not the company. She would need to remain enrolled through the program year.
- Timing** The 2026-27 cohort started with a welcome workshop in August 2026, and applications for it are closed. Interviews are held in mid-May. The 2027-28 cycle will presumably open in spring 2027, but no date has been published (unconfirmed).
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/experiences-programs/melissa-doug-
- Why it fits** Amaris is eligible, and the program bundles a grant, executive coaching and Duke alumni/investor network, but the earliest entry is the 2027-28 cohort.
- Contacts** **Amy Linnane**, Managing Director, Programs (profile page titled 'Managing Director, Co-Curricular Programs'), Duke I&E; runs all co-curricular programming incl. Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs, amy.linnane@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/amy-linnane
Melissa C. Smith, Senior Program Coordinator, Duke I&E, entrepreneurship.duke.edu/staff
Duke I&E general inbox, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

New Ventures course sequence (I&E 385 Discover, I&E 395 Develop, I&E 396 Deliver)

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

High fit

Duke I&E (originated in Fuqua's New Venture courses) · Course / training

- What you get** A for-credit venture-building course sequence. New Ventures: Deliver (I&E 396, cross-listed MMS 396) is the advanced capstone. Completing it is a prerequisite for the \$25K Seed Stage Startup Award, and it earns preference for the Interplay Fellowship.
- Eligibility** Duke students. New Ventures Deliver is for entrepreneurs who passed the evaluation in New Ventures Develop and have early revenue or evidence of product-market fit. SimReal: likely. Amaris can enroll if she clears the Develop evaluation.
- Timing** Semester offerings and prerequisites were not found in searches. Check the Duke course registration system for Spring 2027.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/courses-certificates/undergraduate ; markets.duke.edu/courses/new-ventures-deliver
- Why it fits** The course is the gateway to the \$25K Seed Stage Award, and Amaris could work on SimReal for credit.
- Contacts** **Duke I&E general inbox**, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Interplay Fellows

SimReal qualifies: unclear

unconfirmed

High fit

Duke I&E (funded by a \$1M gift from Interplay, a NYC startup ecosystem) · Fellowship / program

- What you get** A one-time non-dilutive award of up to \$40,000, paid in two instalments 6 months apart, so a graduating student founder can work on the startup full time. One fellow per year so far: John Xu '25 (Alleviate Health) in 2025 and Adam Berthold MBA '26 (Deep Marine Innovations) in 2026.
- Eligibility** Graduating Duke students from any degree program pursuing a for-profit or non-profit venture. Preference goes to students with demonstrated financial need and high Duke I&E engagement (e.g., Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs, New Ventures courses). SimReal: unclear. It qualifies only in the year Amaris graduates and goes full time on SimReal. Her class year is not known.
- Timing** Awarded around graduation (spring). No 2027 deadline was found.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/resource/interplay-fellows
- Why it fits** At \$40K it is the largest Duke non-dilutive award for an individual founder, but only if Amaris graduates (e.g., May 2027) and commits full time.
- Contacts** **Duke I&E general inbox**, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Seed Stage Startup Award

SimReal qualifies: unclear

unconfirmed

High fit

Duke I&E · Funding: non-dilutive

- What you get** Up to \$25,000 in non-dilutive funding plus a dedicated mentor support team.
- Eligibility** Full-time Duke student who has completed New Ventures: Deliver (I&E 396), shows ongoing traction and market validation, and will stay enrolled at Duke for at least one more year. SimReal: unclear. It qualifies only if Amaris has completed, or completes, New Ventures Deliver and has at least one more year at Duke.
- Timing** No deadline found. It follows completion of New Ventures Deliver.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/resource/seed-stage-startup-award (ask entrepreneurship@duke.edu for the cycle)
- Why it fits** It is the largest I&E grant for current students. SimReal's traction (Xitadel) fits the 'market validation' bar if Amaris takes the course path.
- Contacts** **Duke I&E general inbox**, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu
Jamie N. Jones, PhD, Director, Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship; Associate Professor of the Practice of Management, Fuqua (former Executive Director, Fuqua CEI), jamie.j@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/jamie-jones

Duke Student Startup Funding (micro-grants)

SimReal qualifies: yes

rolling

Medium fit

Duke I&E · Funding: non-dilutive

- What you get** Non-dilutive awards of \$500, with at most 10 per semester. Example uses: website build, hosting, customer discovery, app development.
- Eligibility** All current Duke students. Priority goes to students engaged with Duke I&E programs, first-time recipients, and past recipients who completed the post-award survey. SimReal qualifies through Amaris.
- Timing** Awarded each semester. No specific deadline was found.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/duke-student-startup-funding
- Why it fits** Easy to get and non-dilutive, but \$500 is small next to a seed round. It also builds the I&E engagement record that other awards prefer.
- Contacts** **Duke I&E general inbox**, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Alison Bernstein Venture Activation Fund

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

Medium fit

Duke I&E (gift of Alison Bernstein P'26, P'27, P'30) · Funding: non-dilutive

- What you get** Support for Duke student founders to access tools, expertise and professional services for their ventures. Amount not found.
- Eligibility** Duke student founders. Detailed criteria not found. SimReal: likely, through Amaris.
- Timing** Not found.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/startup-support/funding (ask entrepreneurship@duke.edu)
- Why it fits** It could pay for professional services (e.g., legal/accounting for the seed round), but its size and terms are unknown.
- Contacts** **Duke I&E general inbox**, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Christensen Family Center for Innovation (CFCI)

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

Medium fit

- Pratt founder support

Pratt School of Engineering · Fellowship / program

- What you get** Coaching, mentorship and programs for Duke students and alumni building technology ventures: 1:1 coaching, Founders Fridays (monthly open mentoring for student founders, Spring 2026), Duke Product Lab, Pratt Founders, A. James Clark Scholars, and Baquerizo Innovation Grants (see separate entry).
- Eligibility** Duke students and alumni building tech products. Whether non-Pratt students can join every offering is not confirmed. SimReal: likely through Amaris.
- Timing** Founders Fridays ran monthly in Spring 2026. The 2026-27 schedule was not found.
- How to apply** cfci.pratt.duke.edu ; pratt.duke.edu/academics/undergrad/entrepreneurship
- Why it fits** Free technical-product coaching and engineering-founder network suit an AI/RL infrastructure company, though no direct seed money.
- Contacts** **Steven McClelland**, Executive Director, Christensen Family Center for Innovation, cfci.pratt.duke.edu/people
Adria Dunbar, Managing Director, Christensen Family Center for Innovation (oversees Duke Product Lab and Pratt Founders), cfci.pratt.duke.edu/people/adria-dunbar-2
Anna Wilson, Executive in Residence and Director of Product Lab, CFCI, cfci.pratt.duke.edu/people

Duke Deep Tech (Sanford School) - AI/semiconductors/quantum network

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

Medium fit

Duke Sanford School of Public Policy · Network / community

- What you get** An interdisciplinary effort bridging research, industry and policy in semiconductors, AI, quantum computing, climate finance and cybersecurity. It hosts founder events such as 'From Duke to OpenAI-Backed Startup: Meet Endex AI CEO Tarun Amasa' (Mar 25, 2026). It is co-led by Ronnie Chatterji, who is OpenAI's chief economist. Not a funder.
- Eligibility** Duke community events. SimReal: likely through Amaris for attendance and networking.
- Timing** Event-based. The 2026-27 calendar was not found.
- How to apply** deeptech.duke.edu
- Why it fits** Its AI-industry network, including the OpenAI link and the Endex founder (an AI-for-finance company like SimReal), is relevant to an RL-environments startup.
- Contacts** **David Hoffman**, Professor of the Practice, Sanford School; Managing Director, Duke Deep Tech, deeptech.duke.edu/staff
Ronnie Chatterji, Fuqua professor; co-leads Duke Deep Tech; OpenAI chief economist, deeptech.duke.edu/staff
Merritt Cahoon, Deep Tech Program Coordinator, deeptech.duke.edu/profile/merritt-cahoon

Duke Law Start-Up Ventures Clinic (SUVC)

Duke University School of Law · Legal / IP / services

SimReal qualifies: unclear

open

Medium fit

- What you get** Free legal advice and representation from supervised law students for entrepreneurs and seed/early-stage ventures. Covers company formation, founder equity and vesting, shareholder agreements, IP protection and licensing, commercialization strategy and operational issues.
- Eligibility** North Carolina entrepreneurs with a specific legal matter, who come from Duke's campus, the Triangle and across NC. Ventures should not yet have raised significant outside capital. Clients are selected on their ability to afford market-rate counsel and the clinic's teaching needs. SimReal: unclear. The Duke-campus founder helps, but SimReal must count as an NC client, and a priced seed round may take it out of scope.
- Timing** Applications go live about one month before each semester (August and January). Applications were open for Fall 2026. Spring 2027 intake is expected around December 2026 (inferred from the stated pattern).
- How to apply** law.duke.edu/startupventures (online application)
- Why it fits** Free help with founder vesting, IP assignment and SAFE/seed documents would save money before the round closes, if SimReal is accepted as an NC client.
- Contacts** **Bryan McGann**, Clinical Professor of Law; Director, Start-Up Ventures Clinic and Program in Law & Entrepreneurship, bryan.mcgann@duke.edu, law.duke.edu/fac/mcgann
SUVC clinic inbox, Generic clinic inbox (phone 919-613-7169), suvc@law.duke.edu, law.duke.edu/startupventures/contactus

Duke Entrepreneurial Leaders Network (ELN)

Duke I&E (with OTC and Pratt) · Network / community

SimReal qualifies: unclear

unconfirmed

Medium fit

- What you get** A selective network of about 100 members (15 inducted in 2026, spanning AI, health tech, deep tech and life sciences). Members get ongoing access to opportunities from Duke I&E, OTC, Pratt and Triangle ventures, invitations to explore Duke IP spinouts, and introductions to Duke founders who need executive talent.
- Eligibility** Duke alumni and current students in their final year who are committed to founding or leading an innovation-driven startup. SimReal: unclear. Amaris qualifies only in her final year, or after she graduates.
- Timing** Annual cohort (2026 cohort announced). The next application window was not found.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/duke-eln
- Why it fits** It connects Amaris to high-caliber Duke founders and operators, useful for hiring and investor introductions, once she is in her final year.
- Contacts** **Josh Cohen (MBA '07)**, Director of MBA Entrepreneurship Programs and Startup Recruiting, Duke I&E (runs Startup Sprint, Innovators' Spark, ELN application process)
Duke I&E general inbox, Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu, entrepreneurship.duke.edu

LAUNCH for Early-Stage Founders

Duke I&E · Accelerator / incubator

SimReal qualifies: unclear

unconfirmed

Medium fit

What you get	Up to \$1,000 in non-dilutive funding each semester. Also bi-weekly cohort meetups (every other Wednesday, starting in September), expert-led sessions on building, pitching and scaling, early access to visiting VCs and Duke alumni investors, and an invitation to Founders Weekend.
Eligibility	By invitation only, for early-stage Duke student founders. SimReal: unclear. Amaris would need an invitation from Duke I&E.
Timing	Cohort meetups start in September. Whether a 2026-27 cohort is running, or still accepts members, is unconfirmed.
How to apply	entrepreneurship.duke.edu/startup-support/launch-early-stage (ask Duke I&E about an invitation)
Why it fits	Early access to visiting VCs and Duke alumni investors helps a live seed raise. The cash is small.
Contacts	Amy Linnane , Managing Director, Programs (profile page titled 'Managing Director, Co-Curricular Programs'), Duke I&E; runs all co-curricular programming incl. Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs, amy.linnane@duke.edu , entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/amy-linnane Duke I&E general inbox , Generic program inbox (Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 100 Fuqua Drive, Durham NC 27708), entrepreneurship@duke.edu , entrepreneurship.duke.edu

Lower fit · 12

Program	What you get	Why lower fit
Duke I&E Summer Startup Sprint Duke I&E · qualifies: yes	A free six-week virtual sprint on Zoom, Wednesdays 11:00-12:30 ET, covering customer discovery, problem definition, competition analysis, assumption...	SimReal is already past the idea stage this sprint covers.
Duke Innovation Co-Lab Innovation Grants (and Roots workshops) Duke OIT Innovation Co-Lab · qualifies: likely	Small seed grants (supported projects average under \$1,000) plus one-on-one mentorship, mainly for materials, equipment and components.	The grants are sub-\$1K, for physical materials, and aimed at pre-startup projects.
Ronald & Carrie Ludwig Duke in Silicon Valley Duke I&E · qualifies: likely	A month-long summer course in which students live in the Bay Area: guest speakers from startups and tech companies, lectures, case studies and...	It is a credit course, not company support, though the month in the Bay Area could produce investor meetings.
I&E Undergraduate Certificate Duke I&E · qualifies: likely	An undergraduate certificate in Innovation & Entrepreneurship, which includes the New Ventures course pathway.	An academic credential, though its courses overlap with the New Ventures path to the Seed Stage Award.
Baquerizo Innovation Grant (BIG) / CFCI GoBig awards Pratt School of Engineering - CFCI (funded by the Baquerizo Family) · qualifies: unclear	Sources disagree on the amounts.	The awards are small, need faculty nomination and an impact framing, and mainly fund prototypes.
I&E+ summer experiential program Duke I&E · qualifies: unclear	A 10-week summer program that pairs teams of two Duke students with partner startups or local organizations to work on strategic projects using...	At most a source of two free summer student analysts.
InCube residential incubator Duke (student entrepreneurial residential program) · qualifies: unclear	A historical Duke entrepreneurial living community.	There is no evidence it currently operates.

Duke Engineering Entrepreneurship Program (DEEP) Duke Biomedical Engineering (Pratt) · qualifies: no	One year of salary support through the first year of a new venture, plus an entrepreneurial advising team, a workshop series (founder stories, IP),...	Limited to BME PhD research ventures.
Duke campus AI suite (ChatGPT Edu, Microsoft Copilot, DukeGPT, Anthropic Claude pay-as-you-go) Duke OIT / Provost's AI initiative · qualifies: no	Individual-use AI tools for students: free ChatGPT access (OpenAI pilot, later ChatGPT Edu), Microsoft Copilot, DukeGPT, and paid consumption-based...	It is not company compute.
Duke Capital Partners Associate Program Duke Capital Partners · qualifies: no	A two-year training program in which Duke trainees run due diligence on the roughly 1,000 opportunities DCP sees each year, covering sourcing,...	Not funding, but current associates are useful Duke contacts during DCP diligence.
Fuqua Center for Entrepreneurship and Innovation (CEI) and Fuqua venture programs (incl. Summer E-ternship Awards) Duke Fuqua School of Business · qualifies: no	Fuqua's home for entrepreneurship.	Its funding is for MBA students.
Office for Translation & Commercialization (OTC) Duke University · qualifies: no	Protects Duke-owned IP, licenses technology, launches Duke spinouts and connects researchers to translational funding.	SimReal has no Duke IP.

Duke networks and student funds · 17

Duke I&E regional networking events (NYC Networking Night, other cities) via Duke Alumni events

SimReal qualifies: yes

rolling

High fit

Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship / Duke Alumni Association · Network / community

What you get	In-person networking with Duke alumni and parents who are founders, investors and operators. One example is the Duke I&E NYC Networking Night hosted at Primary Venture Partners (386 Park Ave S, NYC), with a reception, a program and then more networking. Another is a Duke I&E Philadelphia Networking Event (18 Sep 2025) for Duke alumni and parents in innovation and entrepreneurship, with remarks from Duke I&E leadership. The Duke Alumni Association events calendar also lists Duke I&E programs such as Startup Sprint. No Duke entrepreneurship event in London was found.
Eligibility	Duke alumni, parents, students and community members. A current Duke undergraduate co-founder qualifies.
Timing	Recurring regional events. No 2026-27 dates were confirmed in search; check the alumni.duke.edu events calendar.
How to apply	Register on alumni.duke.edu/events/duke-ie-nyc-networking-night and watch alumni.duke.edu/get-involved/groups and the Duke I&E events pages
Why it fits	The NYC events are hosted at VC offices with Duke investors attending. This is the most active current version of the DukeGEN networking model.
Contacts	Kelley Downey , Event contact listed for Duke I&E events (per search snippet of Duke Alumni event page), alumni.duke.edu/events/duke-ie-nyc-networking-night

Towerview Ventures (Alumni Ventures' Duke fund)

SimReal qualifies: yes

rolling

High fit

Alumni Ventures · Funding: equity

- What you get** Venture investment from Alumni Ventures' fund for Duke alumni and friends. It invests in companies with a Duke connection through founders, team members or advisors. It co-invests alongside lead VCs; cited co-investors include a16z, Sequoia and Y Combinator. It reaches a community of 21k+ Duke alumni and friends. Check size was not published in any source found.
- Eligibility** Startups anywhere with a Duke connection (founder, team member or advisor). Usually takes part alongside a lead investor.
- Timing** Rolling. Best approached once a seed lead or term sheet is in place, since Towerview co-invests alongside leads.
- How to apply** www.av.vc/funds/towerview (Towerview page). A scheduling page is at www.av.vc/funds/towerview/tvv-calendly, but its audience is unconfirmed and may be investors. The fund is also on LinkedIn at www.linkedin.com/company/towerview-ventures
- Why it fits** SimReal's Duke undergraduate co-founder meets the Duke-connection test, and Towerview can fill out the seed round alongside a lead.
- Contacts** **Greg Baker (Fuqua '91)**, Managing Partner, Alumni Ventures (since 2017); runs Towerview Ventures, superscout.co/investor/towerview-ventures
Ali Byrd (Duke '95), Described as Managing Partner of Towerview Ventures in an Alumni Ventures Medium profile (date not verified; may be a former role), medium.com/@alumniventures/meet-ali-byrd-95-managing-partner

Dorm Room Fund (Philly & Southeast team covers Duke)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

High fit

Dorm Room Fund (First Round-founded, student-run) · Funding: equity

- What you get** Investment from a student-run VC that backs startups founded by college students and recent graduates in the US and Canada. It closed a new \$50M fund (about 4x the previous one), and about 60 student investors a year make decisions across about 30 campuses. It has financed 400+ student founders across 250+ startups. Its Philly & Southeast team covers North Carolina, including Duke. Check size was not verified in this search.
- Eligibility** Founders who are current students or recent graduates (US and Canada).
- Timing** Rolling for founders. The student investment-partner application closed on 17 Sep.
- How to apply** www.dormroomfund.com (founder pitch). Partner recruiting is at join.dormroomfund.com
- Why it fits** SimReal has a current Duke undergraduate and recent-graduate co-founders, which is exactly DRF's mandate, and DRF has a newly enlarged fund.
- Duke angle** SimReal clearly meets the student-founder test through Amaris (Duke), and a freshly raised \$50M fund means capital is available now. Duke falls in DRF's Philly & Southeast region. Pre-seed equity checks decided by student investment teams. Recent reporting says student teams write \$40,000 checks; other third-party profiles cite larger ranges (\$90K-\$500K) after the new fund, which DRF's own site does not confirm. In late Sept 2026 DRF closed a new \$50M fund (about 4x the prior fund) for student and alumni founders. Around 60 student investors a year across about 30 campuses, with professional oversight on terms and diligence.
- Contacts** **Christina Liang**, Student Investment Partner, Dorm Room Fund Philly & Southeast team; described as a Duke senior (Statistics and French). The interview is undated, so she may have graduated., www.boringbusinessnerd.com/post/investing-at-dorm-room-fund-
Madison Jacox, Named as part of DRF's professional oversight on terms and diligence (title not verified)

Duke Experts in Entrepreneurship (volunteer office hours)

SimReal qualifies: yes

rolling

Medium fit

Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship · Network / community

- What you get** Weekly 1:1 office hours with volunteer experts who give advice and ad hoc support to Duke alumni and students.
- Eligibility** Duke alumni and students.
- Timing** Weekly, ongoing.
- How to apply** entrepreneurship.duke.edu/duke-experts-entrepreneurship
- Why it fits** Free expert time for fundraising and go-to-market advice, which can lead to warm intros.

DukeGEN (Duke Global Entrepreneurship Network)

SimReal qualifies: yes

unconfirmed

Medium fit

DukeGEN (alumni-volunteer network, linked to Duke I&E) · Network / community

- What you get** Access to a large Duke entrepreneur network: about 9,500 members by one listing, and 13,000 claimed in a speaker bio. Started in 2008. Historically ran 30+ events a year: an Elevator Pitch Competition, the Duke Start-Up Challenge, a Startup Speaker Series, Startup Showcases and multi-city networking events. Alumni volunteers ran networking events about three times a year for alumni, students, faculty and staff. The only city chapter found is Seattle, where Chris Haberle is listed as co-chair. No London chapter or DukeGEN-branded 2025-26 event was found. Duke I&E's regional events (see separate item) now seem to fill this role. The search found no separate 'Duke Entrepreneurs Network'; the name seems to refer to DukeGEN or the Duke I&E Network.
- Eligibility** Open to Duke students, faculty, staff, alumni, parents and friends of Duke.
- Timing** No 2026-27 DukeGEN-branded events found. Historically, networking events ran three times a year.
- How to apply** Join and follow the network at sites.google.com/view/dukegen and www.linkedin.com/company/dukegen
- Why it fits** A large Duke founder and investor audience that suits warm intros. Activity looks low, so use Duke I&E events for live programming.
- Duke angle** The format is ideal (Duke investors in NYC and SF), but the series may be dormant. A chance to pitch to a panel of Duke alumni judges and investors, plus networking with Duke alumni in entrepreneurship. DukeGEN picked about six Duke-founded startups per showcase and held showcases every year in NYC and SF. The last ones confirmed are the 19th (NYC, 10 Dec 2018, at Yext) and the 18th (SF, 20 Jun 2018, WeWork Embarcadero). Past winners include Ello Raw and Swell Energy.
- Contacts** **Chris Haberle**, DukeGEN Seattle chapter co-chair (per his public profile snippet; whether the role is current is not verified), www.linkedin.com/in/chrishaberle
Howie Rhee, DukeGEN co-founder in 2008, with T. Reid Lewis and Jon Fjeld (current role not verified), blog.dukegen.com/2009/02/blurb-about-duke-global.html

BlueRidge Ventures (pre-seed AI fund sourcing from Duke alumni)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

BlueRidge Ventures · Funding: equity

- What you get** Investment from a \$3M pre-seed (and seed, per one listing) fund. It backs AI-native, sector-agnostic US founders, sourced from Duke alumni and the Research Triangle venture community. It appears on a VC Lab list of emerging funds (July 2026), which suggests it was still raising from LPs then.
- Eligibility** AI-native US founders at pre-seed/seed with Duke or Triangle ties.
- Timing** Rolling. Fund status (whether it has closed) unconfirmed.
- How to apply** No public founder application form found. The fund is listed at decilepro.com/access/blueridgeventures; contact the founder directly.
- Why it fits** Its AI and Duke-alumni thesis matches SimReal, but it is a small pre-seed fund, so checks will be small, and the US-founder focus may matter given the UK-based co-founders.
- Contacts** **Nikhil Mittal**, Founder & Investment Lead, BlueRidge Ventures, decilepro.com/access/blueridgeventures

Duke Venture Group (DVG) - undergraduate VC organization / scout program

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

Duke Venture Group (student-run) · Network / community

- What you get** Visibility with VC firms that use DVG for sourcing and diligence. Each semester DVG writes due-diligence reports and market research for partner VCs; named partners include Duke I&E, Duke Capital Partners, Straylight Capital, Techstars, Red Bike Capital and Maven Ventures. Superscout lists DVG as Duke's scout program. As a Duke undergraduate, Amaris could also join as an analyst, though that may create a conflict of interest.
- Eligibility** Members must be Duke undergraduates. Startups can be sourced or presented through members.
- Timing** Recruits each semester (6-8 week analyst curriculum). Exact 2026-27 dates not found.
- How to apply** www.dukeventuregroup.org ; contact via contact@dukeventuregroup.com
- Why it fits** Student-run, but its partner firms (Straylight, Techstars, Red Bike and others) are potential seed investors reachable via a Duke-undergraduate warm path.
- Contacts** **Nate Goldin**, Founder & President (as listed on DVG team page; may be outdated), contact@dukeventuregroup.com, www.dukeventuregroup.com/team
Diego Keller, Co-Founder & Executive Vice President (as listed on DVG team page), www.dukeventuregroup.com/team
Sam Elkin, Co-Founder & Executive Vice President (as listed on DVG team page), www.dukeventuregroup.com/team
Terrence Ware, Co-Founder & Vice President of Finance (as listed on DVG team page), www.dukeventuregroup.com/team

Soma Capital Fellowship (Soma Fellows)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

Soma Capital · Funding: equity

- What you get** \$100K-\$1M on uncapped SAFEs (per Superscout listing) for exceptional technical founders and student builders. No Duke campus scout was found.
- Eligibility** Technical founders and student builders.
- Timing** Rolling. Soma has invited past applicants to send updates.
- How to apply** programs.somacap.com/fellows
- Why it fits** Meaningful uncapped-SAFE capital for a technical team, but no Duke channel.

NGEN Student Entrepreneurship Conference (Durham)

SimReal qualifies: likely

upcoming

Medium fit

NGEN (501(c)(3) intercollegiate entrepreneurship org) with Research Triangle Park · Competition / prize

What you get A full-day conference with keynotes, pitch showcases of student ventures, and networking with student founders, startup leaders and industry. It draws students from Duke, UNC, NC State and other NC universities. Promoted on Duke Career Hub.

Eligibility Student founders and builders from NC universities.

Timing Friday 23 Oct 2026 at Frontier RTP, 800 Park Offices Dr, Durham, NC.

How to apply www.ngennetwork.org (see Duke Career Hub post: careerhub.students.duke.edu/blog/2026/09/21/connect-build-ex)

Why it fits Soon and local to Duke, with a pitch showcase. The audience is mostly students, with fewer seed investors.

Lower fit - 8

Program	What you get	Why lower fit
Superscout Duke hub (directory of scout programs at Duke) Superscout · qualifies: yes	A directory of VC scout and student-fund programs available at Duke: Duke Venture Group, Rise of the Rest Seed Fund Fellowship, Front Row Ventures...	A mapping tool for scout warm paths rather than capital itself.
Duke Venture Community (DVC) - NYC Meetup Duke Venture Community (independent) · qualifies: yes	A private, independent NYC community (648 members on Meetup) for Duke students, alumni and employees interested in entrepreneurship.	A small NYC Duke community.
Z Fellows Z Fellows · qualifies: likely	A one-week program in San Francisco with \$10,000 (investment at a \$1B valuation cap, converting at the next priced round;	The money is small and suits an earlier stage than a seed raise.
Afore Capital (campus scouts) Afore Capital · qualifies: unclear	No Duke campus scout or student program was found for Afore.	No Duke channel was found, and the program details are unverified.
Duke Investment Club Duke Investment Club (student-run) · qualifies: unclear	A student investing club at dukeiclub.org.	No startup funding or venture activity was confirmed.
Duke Women's Impact Network (WIN) / Duke women-in-business networks Duke University · qualifies: unclear	No founder-funding or entrepreneurship program from Duke WIN or a Duke Women in Business group was found.	No entrepreneurship or funding offering was confirmed.
Fuqua Entrepreneurship & Venture Capital Club (EVCC) and Fuqua alumni networking Duke Fuqua School of Business · qualifies: unclear	An MBA club that connects alumni, entrepreneurs and VCs through networking events, panels, seminars and brainstorming lunches, with links to the...	Indirect value, mainly MBA talent and alumni-VC intros.
Venture Capital Investment Competition (VCIC) at Duke Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship (resource listing) · qualifies: unclear	Duke I&E lists VCIC as a resource and held a VCIC kickoff on 8 Oct 2025.	The startup role and investor exposure are unverified.

American Underground (coworking, community, FCAT Fellowship)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

High fit

American Underground (Durham; Capitol Broadcasting Company) · Network / community

What you get Durham's long-running startup hub ('Startup Hub of the South'). It moved back to American Tobacco Campus (Bays 9-10), with a grand opening in June 2026 and programming from 18 Jun. Offers coworking, events and community. Its FCAT Fellowship gives fellows a 12-month all-access coworking membership plus in-person full-day workshops in Durham (listed 17 Jun to 27 Aug). Membership fees apply; no equity.

Eligibility Coworking is open to paying members. Fellowship criteria were not found.

Timing Coworking is rolling. The FCAT Fellowship ran summer 2026; 2027 dates unconfirmed.

How to apply americanunderground.com/fcat

Why it fits It is in downtown Durham, minutes from Duke. It would give Amaris a credible Triangle base and address and fast access to local founders and investors. It also strengthens an NC-HQ case for NC IDEA.

Contacts **Laura Zabinski**, Executive Director, American Underground (per 2026 reporting)

Bull City Venture Partners (BCVP)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

High fit

Bull City Venture Partners (Durham) · Funding: equity

What you get VC equity. Often the first institutional investor, leading pre-seed, seed and Series A rounds in B2B software and tech-enabled businesses (aggregators cite \$1M-\$5M checks). It also runs 'Founders First', a half-day event where founders meet capital partners and operators.

Eligibility B2B software and tech-enabled companies, mainly in the Southeast. No formal entity rule was found.

Timing Rolling. Founders First event dates not found.

How to apply www.bcvp.com/founders-first (fund website; no public deck-submission form verified)

Why it fits SimReal sells B2B to AI labs, and a Durham-based seed lead suits a company anchored at Duke.

Cofounders Capital

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

High fit

Cofounders Capital (Cary, NC) · Funding: equity

What you get Seed equity from Fund III, a \$50M fund for B2B software at seed stage with a special focus on NC. Checks of \$500K-\$2M; partners are former founders and help with Triangle recruiting.

Eligibility B2B software companies in the Southeast, especially NC.

Timing Rolling. Active (3 new investments in the 12 months to Aug 2026).

How to apply cofounderscapital.com

Why it fits Its B2B software thesis and NC focus match a Durham-anchored SimReal seed round.

ACC InVenture Prize 2027

SimReal qualifies: likely

upcoming

High fit

Atlantic Coast Conference (ACC) Academic Consortium; Duke selects its team · Competition / prize

- What you get** Non-dilutive cash prizes: \$15,000 first place, \$10,000 second, \$5,000 People's Choice (\$30,000 total). It is a televised and streamed pitch final with high visibility.
- Eligibility** Each ACC university (Duke included) sends one team. Teams may include only full-time, degree-seeking undergraduates or recent graduates within one year of graduation. No entity rule.
- Timing** Faculty representative application due 23 Jan 2027. Student team representative application due 30 Jan 2027. Pitch video due 17 Feb 2027. Finals 16-17 Mar 2027, hosted by the University of Notre Dame. Duke's internal selection date was not found.
- How to apply** www.accinventureprize.com/rules (apply through Duke's internal selection)
- Why it fits** Amaris is a Duke undergraduate, so SimReal can compete for Duke's single slot. Prize money is equity-free with no NC or US entity rule. Check whether non-Duke co-founders can be on the pitching team.

Launch Powered by KPMG accelerator

SimReal qualifies: likely

upcoming

High fit

Launch Chapel Hill (Town of Chapel Hill / UNC / KPMG partnership) · Accelerator / incubator

- What you get** An equity-free accelerator that describes itself as AI-enabled. Launch takes no equity, and the program is open to founders with or without a UNC affiliation. Summer accelerators are separate and need at least one UNC-student founder; a student international trip program to European ecosystems ran Jun-Jul 2026.
- Eligibility** Open to all innovators for the KPMG, Fall and Spring accelerators. No NC-entity or ownership rule was found.
- Timing** Cohort 4: applications closed 31 Jul 2026; program 14 Sep to 20 Oct 2026. Cohort 3 began Mar 2026, so expect a spring 2027 cohort (dates unconfirmed).
- How to apply** www.launchchapelhill.com/kpmg-accelerator (application form: www.tfaforms.com/443844)
- Why it fits** Equity-free, AI-themed, open to non-UNC founders and about 20 minutes from Duke. It is one of the few Triangle accelerators SimReal can join without restructuring.
- Contacts** **Emil Runge**, Executive Director, Launch Chapel Hill (appointed Jan 2025), innovate.unc.edu/emil-runge-joins-launch-chapel-hill-as-new-

CED Venture Connect 2027 (pitch showcase and investor conference)

SimReal qualifies: unclear

upcoming

High fit

CED (Council for Entrepreneurial Development) · Network / community

- What you get** The largest investor-facing startup conference in the Southeast. Selected companies present to investors. Tracks include Software Innovation and Next-Gen Hardware & Deep Tech. VC26 (24-25 Mar 2026, DPAC Durham) had 100+ presenting companies.
- Eligibility** Scaling startups chosen through a pitch application. Whether out-of-state or non-US companies qualify was not verified.
- Timing** Venture Connect 2027: 23-24 Mar 2027. For 2026, pitch applications closed before founders were told of next steps by mid-Feb, so 2027 applications probably open in late 2026 or January 2027 (unconfirmed).
- How to apply** cednc.org/venture-connect/pitch
- Why it fits** It is held in Durham and has a Software Innovation track, and it is the single densest room of Triangle and Southeast investors. That makes it a strong showcase for SimReal's seed raise.
- Contacts** **Alex Bloom**, CEO, CED (effective 1 Jan 2026), cednc.org/ced-announces-leadership-transition

NC IDEA SEED grant

SimReal qualifies: unclear

upcoming

High fit

NC IDEA (Durham-based private foundation) · Funding: non-dilutive

- What you get** \$50,000 non-dilutive grant plus mentorship, programming and structured guidance. Aimed at early-stage companies with a proven concept that plan to raise venture capital within two years or reach \$2M+ annual revenue within five years. A company can apply to MICRO or SEED in a cycle, not both.
- Eligibility** Requires an NC company: headquartered in NC with the majority of corporate operations in NC, registered with a state with a federal EIN, founder(s) residing in NC, and identified as an NC company in all public materials. No US-citizenship ownership rule was found in search results.
- Timing** Two cycles a year. Spring 2026 deadline was 23 Feb 2026 (21 semi-finalists named Mar 2026). Fall 2026 deadline was 24 Aug 2026 (info-session webinar 13 Jul 2026). Spring 2027 dates were not found; going by the 2026 pattern, expect a deadline around late Feb 2027.
- How to apply** ncidea.org/nc-idea-seed
- Why it fits** This is the largest equity-free startup grant in NC, and SimReal is in its venture-track target group. It is only reachable if SimReal is headquartered in NC (e.g. Durham, where Amaris is based) and the NC-residency rule for founders is met.
- Contacts** **Thom Ruhe**, President & CEO, NC IDEA, kenaninstitute.unc.edu/people/thom-ruhe

Raleigh-Durham Startup Week (RDSW)

SimReal qualifies: yes

upcoming

Medium fit

Raleigh-Durham Startup Week · Network / community

- What you get** An annual free startup week of events. RDSW26 (Apr 2026) included a Founder's Clinic, a 'Bad Pitches' session and investor open houses, such as Bullhouse's launch.
- Eligibility** Open to the public.
- Timing** RDSW26 was April 2026; RDSW27 dates unconfirmed (probably spring 2027).
- How to apply** See GrepBeat coverage; official site URL not verified
- Why it fits** A cheap way for Amaris to meet Triangle founders and investors in one week.

Bullhouse (Durham founder hub and micro-checks)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

Bullhouse Ventures · Funding: equity

What you get First checks of \$5K-\$10K (described as \$5,000 angel checks) plus deal-by-deal SPVs of up to \$100K. Portfolio founders get free coworking, a podcast and video studio, a conference room and a PO box. The space is designed for a cohort of 10-15 full-time founders.

Eligibility Early-stage startups, focused on fintech, sports tech, health tech, defence tech and martech. Founders work from the Durham space.

Timing Launched Apr 2026 at Raleigh-Durham Startup Week. Rolling.

How to apply bullhouseventures.com

Why it fits Small money but a free Durham base. SimReal's Xitadel trading environment gives a fintech angle that matches the stated thesis.

Contacts **Austin Armstrong**, Co-founder, Bullhouse, x.com/SocialtyPro
Austin Carroll, Co-founder, Bullhouse

IDEA Fund Partners

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

IDEA Fund Partners (Durham) · Funding: equity

What you get Seed and early-stage VC equity in technology companies. IDEA Fund IV launched Jan 2023 with a narrower geographic focus and an aim to back more diverse entrepreneurs. It often co-invests with Front Porch Venture Partners.

Eligibility Seed and early-stage tech, Southeast focus.

Timing Rolling.

How to apply Fund website (URL not verified in this research); public profile: x.com/ideafund

Why it fits A Durham seed fund investing in tech. Its thesis on AI infrastructure is unverified.

Triangle Angel Partners (TAP)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

Triangle Angel Partners · Funding: equity

What you get Angel equity at seed and Series A from a member group of executives, PhDs, entrepreneurs and professional investors (founded 2011, Chapel Hill). Per aggregator sources, finalists pitch to the full accredited-investor membership at monthly dinner meetings after a screening committee and panel.

Eligibility Strong preference for NC and Research Triangle companies. Expects an MVP plus early customer validation or pilot revenue, a deck, an executive summary and 3-year projections (aggregator-reported).

Timing Rolling, with monthly meetings.

How to apply www.sparkxyz.io/applications/1235 (TAP application on Spark XYZ)

Why it fits The most structured local angel route for a seed round. The NC preference favours a Durham-based setup.

NSF SBIR/STTR Phase I (America's Seed Fund), Artificial Intelligence topic

US National Science Foundation · Funding: non-dilutive

SimReal qualifies: unclear

open

Medium fit

- What you get** Phase I up to \$305,000 non-dilutive and equity-free; Phase II up to \$1.25M. Fast-Track is available, plus a new Strategic Breakthrough tier (about \$30M). Solicitation NSF 26-510 deploys \$250M in total. The AI topic covers deep-learning AI systems that are safe, reliable, robust to adversaries, privacy-preserving and efficient.
- Eligibility** Federal SBIR/STTR eligibility: a US-located for-profit small business (fewer than 500 employees) that is more than 50% (commonly stated as 51%) owned by US citizens or permanent residents; NSF also excludes firms majority-owned by multiple VC/PE/hedge funds. If SimReal's Cambridge/LSE co-founders are not US citizens or green-card holders and together hold more than 50%, SimReal is NOT eligible, whatever entity it forms. A US entity (e.g. a Delaware C-corp) is needed in any case. A three-page Project Pitch must be invited before a full proposal (at most 2 pitches per company per 12 months).
- Timing** SBIR/STTR authority lapsed Oct 2025 and was reauthorized in spring 2026 through 30 Sep 2031 (one source dates it to 13 Apr 2026, another to March 2026). NSF relaunched on 28 May 2026; Project Pitches reopened 2 Jun 2026. Full-proposal deadlines: 27 Jul 2026 (passed), 4 Nov 2026, 4 Mar 2027.
- How to apply** seedfund.nsf.gov (Project Pitch); solicitation: www.nsf.gov/funding/opportunities/small-business-innovation-
- Why it fits** RL environments and verifiers fit the AI topic's 'safe, reliable, robust' language, and \$305K equity-free is large. But SimReal is ineligible unless more than 50% is owned by US citizens or green-card holders through a US entity. The founders must check their cap table first.

STTR with Duke University as research partner

Federal STTR agencies (NSF, DoD, DOE and others) with Duke as partner · Funding: non-dilutive

SimReal qualifies: unclear

open

Medium fit

- What you get** The same Phase I and II amounts as the agency's SBIR (NSF Phase I up to \$305K; AFWERX STTR Phase I up to \$110K). The startup does at least 40% of the work and a US nonprofit research institution such as Duke does at least 30%; the remaining 30% can go to either.
- Eligibility** Federal SBIR/STTR eligibility: a US-located for-profit small business (fewer than 500 employees) that is more than 50% (commonly stated as 51%) owned by US citizens or permanent residents; NSF also excludes firms majority-owned by multiple VC/PE/hedge funds. If SimReal's Cambridge/LSE co-founders are not US citizens or green-card holders and together hold more than 50%, SimReal is NOT eligible, whatever entity it forms. A US entity (e.g. a Delaware C-corp) is needed in any case. Also needs a US research-institution partner (Duke qualifies as a US nonprofit university) and a signed IP and rights agreement between the company and the institution. Duke's own STTR procedures were not found.
- Timing** Follows each agency's calendar (NSF: 4 Nov 2026, 4 Mar 2027).
- How to apply** Via the agency (e.g. seedfund.nsf.gov) with a Duke faculty collaborator and Duke's sponsored-research or technology-transfer office
- Why it fits** Amaris's Duke tie makes a Duke faculty collaborator realistic, and a Duke partner strengthens an AI-evaluation proposal. But the US-ownership rule applies in the same way as for SBIR.

CED Connections to Capital, mentoring and GRO Incubator

SimReal qualifies: unclear

rolling

Medium fit

CED (Council for Entrepreneurial Development) · Fellowship / program

- What you get** CED introduces high-growth companies to investors that fit their profile ('Connections to Capital'). Also offers founder mentoring, a Mentor Matching Program (help with hires, customers, pricing and fundraising timing) and the GRO Incubator.
- Eligibility** CED partner companies; membership or partnership terms not verified.
- Timing** Rolling.
- How to apply** cednc.org
- Why it fits** Curated investor introductions in the Triangle would complement a Venture Connect application. Costs and terms are unknown.
- Contacts** **Alex Bloom**, CEO, CED (effective 1 Jan 2026), cednc.org/ced-announces-leadership-transition

First Flight Venture Center (RTP incubator and SBIR assistance)

SimReal qualifies: unclear

rolling

Medium fit

First Flight Venture Center (FFVC) · Accelerator / incubator

- What you get** An RTP incubator founded in 1991. Offers pre-accelerator and accelerator cohorts, help with grants and SBIR/STTR, mentor networks, prototyping facilities and investor-readiness work. It holds SBA FAST funding (up to \$125K) to deliver SBIR/STTR outreach and help, especially for underrepresented and rural applicants, and co-runs the SBTDC proposal series.
- Eligibility** Early-stage tech companies. SBIR help is most useful to SBIR-eligible (US-majority-owned) firms. Detailed entry criteria were not found.
- Timing** Rolling incubation. SBIR workshops seasonal (Jun 2026 series; Dec-Feb Road Tour).
- How to apply** www.ffvcnc.org
- Why it fits** It is the Triangle's main source of SBIR know-how. That matters only if SimReal can meet federal ownership rules, and its deep-tech, hardware-leaning tenants are a looser match for an AI-data company.
- Contacts** **Krista Covey**, President & CEO, First Flight Venture Center (appointed 2020; current status not reconfirmed in 2026)
Balaji Vasudevan, Director of Programs, First Flight Venture Center, launch.ffvcnc.org/staff-directory

NC IDEA MICRO grant

SimReal qualifies: unclear

upcoming

Medium fit

NC IDEA · Funding: non-dilutive

- What you get** \$10,000 non-dilutive grant to validate and advance an idea, plus mentorship and programming. Paid as 75% on signing the grant agreement and 25% two months later.
- Eligibility** Requires an NC company: headquartered in NC with the majority of corporate operations in NC, registered with a state with a federal EIN, founder(s) residing in NC, and identified as an NC company in all public materials.
- Timing** Same two cycles a year as SEED. Fall 2026 MICRO recipients have been selected and applications are closed. Spring 2027 dates unconfirmed.
- How to apply** ncidea.org/nc-idea-micro
- Why it fits** Easier to win than SEED but a fifth of the money, and it has the same NC-HQ and founder-residency rule. SEED is the better target for a venture-track AI company.
- Contacts** **Thom Ruhe**, President & CEO, NC IDEA, kenaninstitute.unc.edu/people/thom-ruhe

NC SBTDC SBIR/STTR counseling and workshops

SimReal qualifies: unclear

upcoming

Medium fit

NC Small Business and Technology Development Center
(SBTDC) · Course / training

What you get	Free SBIR/STTR advice. Includes a two-day SBIR/STTR Proposal Development Series run with First Flight (1 and 8 Jun 2026, RTP), a six-stop no-cost statewide hybrid 'Road Tour' of workshops (Dec-Feb), and guidance after the 2025-26 lapse ('how to apply right now').
Eligibility	NC small businesses and entrepreneurs. The federal SBIR ownership rules apply to any resulting proposal.
Timing	Road Tour runs Dec-Feb each year (Dec 2026 to Feb 2027 expected but not confirmed). The proposal series ran Jun 2026.
How to apply	sbtdc.org/site/sbir-sttr-funding
Why it fits	A free way to find out whether SimReal's cap table or a US restructure could qualify for SBIR/STTR before spending effort on it.

Lower fit · 20

Program	What you get	Why lower fit
Raleigh Founded (formerly HQ Raleigh) Raleigh Founded · qualifies: yes	Community coworking at four Raleigh sites (Warehouse, Gateway, Capital Club, Centennial) with networking events, workshops and mentoring.	It is in Raleigh, not Durham, and offers coworking and community rather than funding.
RIoT Accelerator Program (RAP) NC IDEA (RAP moved over from RIoT / Wireless Research Center in Feb 2026) · qualifies: likely	A 12-week hybrid accelerator with industry partnerships, an engineering prototyping lab and links to an industry consortium of 80+ companies across...	Built for IoT and hardware.
Carolina Case Challenge (UNC Kenan-Flagler) UNC Kenan-Flagler Business School · qualifies: unclear	Cash prizes for first to third place in an undergraduate business case competition, split evenly between team members.	A case competition for students, not funding for SimReal.
DOE SBIR/STTR (incl. Genesis Mission AI-for-science topics) US Department of Energy · qualifies: unclear	Phase I grants.	The topics are science-domain AI rather than LLM post-training data.
NIST SBIR Phase I US National Institute of Standards and Technology · qualifies: unclear	Phase I SBIR awards on NIST technical topics, which include artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, advanced manufacturing, quantum and bioscience.	NIST's AI measurement and evaluation focus overlaps with verifiers, but there is one round a year and SimReal is likely ineligible on ownership.
Black Wall Street Homecoming Black Wall Street Homecoming (Durham) · qualifies: unclear	A multi-day Durham gathering celebrating Black entrepreneurship.	Current activity is unverified, and fit depends on founder demographics.
DoD / AFWERX SBIR/STTR (Open Topic) US Department of the Air Force (AFWERX) / DoD SBIR · qualifies: unclear	AFWERX Open Topic Phase I: up to \$75K (SBIR) or \$110K (STTR) for a 3-month feasibility study.	Small Phase I amounts, the strictest foreign-ownership scrutiny and a defence customer requirement.
Durham Rising / Wocstar Academy Durham County, NC IDEA, Knox St. Studios, Wocstar Capital · qualifies: unclear	Durham Rising is a joint Durham County initiative.	A small-business and cash-flow focus.

Front Porch Venture Partners Front Porch Venture Partners · qualifies: unclear	VC equity.	Too little verified information.
Hutton (requested; not identified) Unidentified · qualifies: unclear	No Triangle investor named 'Hutton' could be identified from public search results.	Not verified.
Innovate Durham City of Durham and Durham County · qualifies: unclear	A 16-week program in which startups pilot products or services with a Durham city or county department, with access to staff, data and facilities.	Built for govtech pilots.
Investors' Circle NC (impact angel network) Investors' Circle · qualifies: unclear	An impact-focused angel network.	The NC chapter may no longer be active, and SimReal is not an impact company.
NC Tweener Fund, powered by NC IDEA NC IDEA / Triangle Tweener Investment Fund · qualifies: unclear	Equity investment.	The terms and thesis are unverified.
NC Biotechnology Center loans and grants NC Biotechnology Center (NCBiotech) · qualifies: no	Life-sciences only.	SimReal is not a life-sciences company.
One North Carolina Small Business Program: SBIR/STTR Matching Funds NC Department of Commerce (Board of Science, Technology & Innovation) · qualifies: no	A state grant matching a federal SBIR/STTR Phase I award.	Only relevant once SimReal is an NC-based, majority US-owned company holding a federal Phase I award.
One North Carolina Small Business Program: SBIR/STTR Phase I Incentive Funds NC Department of Commerce (Board of Science, Technology & Innovation) · qualifies: no	Reimburses up to \$12,000 of the cost of preparing a federal Phase I SBIR/STTR proposal (consultants, technical writing, market research, related...	Small, and usable only if SimReal becomes an eligible NC-based SBIR applicant.
Carolina Angel Network (CAN) UNC-Chapel Hill (Innovate Carolina with Kenan-Flagler and UNC School of Law) · qualifies: no	Angel advice and equity investment for UNC-affiliated ventures raising \$100K-\$3M at seed or Series A.	SimReal has no UNC affiliation that we know of.
NC IDEA ECOSYSTEM grant NC IDEA · qualifies: no	Grants to partner organizations that support entrepreneurs across NC (the latest reported cycle funded 18 recipients from 79 applicants).	SimReal is not eligible.
NC Small Business Center Network Startup Showdown NC Community College System, Small Business Center Network (SBCN) · qualifies: no	\$60,000 in startup funding plus mentoring and training.	Limited to not-yet-established NC businesses.
NCInnovation commercialization grants NCInnovation · qualifies: no	Grants and support services for university researchers taking research past proof of concept towards market.	It funds university research projects in non-AI sectors, not founder-led startups.

Student-founder programs and competitions · 40

Pear Competition (Pear Dorm)

Pear VC · Competition / prize

SimReal qualifies: yes

unconfirmed

High fit

- What you get** Winners get a \$100K uncapped SAFE (no discount), up to \$350K in cloud credits and tech benefits, and a fast-track PearX partner meeting. Runners-up may receive \$25K or \$50K investments. Pear Dorm programs (Competition, Garage) give student cohorts \$10K-\$100K each.
- Eligibility** At least one team member must be a current student at a US or Canadian university. Incorporation not required.
- Timing** The 2026-27 competition schedule was not found. Teams can apply to the Competition and PearX at the same time.
- How to apply** pear.vc/competition-application
- Why it fits** Amaris's Duke enrollment alone satisfies the rule. The prize is a meaningful uncapped check plus a fast path into PearX.

Soma Capital Fellowship

Soma Capital · Fellowship / program

SimReal qualifies: yes

closed

High fit

- What you get** \$100,000 on an uncapped SAFE, with access to up to \$2M in follow-on funding, concierge support, office space and customer intros. Fully remote, with optional in-person events.
- Eligibility** Originally for student founders and now open to anyone building an early-stage company; skews to founders in their early to mid 20s. Global, with no relocation.
- Timing** The 2026 application deadline was April 1, 2026. The next cycle date was not found.
- How to apply** superscout.co/program/soma-capital-fellowship (official Soma Capital fellowship page; URL not confirmed)
- Why it fits** An uncapped \$100K with no relocation suits a distributed US/UK team of ~21-year-olds. Watch for the 2027 window.

Y Combinator (W27, incl. Early Decision for students)

Y Combinator · Accelerator / incubator

SimReal qualifies: likely

open

High fit

- What you get** \$500K: \$125K for 7% plus \$375K on a SAFE. Includes a dedicated GP, the alumni network and \$12M+ in partner credits. Early Decision lets students apply while in school, get accepted and funded, and defer the batch until after graduation.
- Eligibility** Open to founders including students. In person in SF for the batch.
- Timing** W27 (Jan-Mar 2027, SF) on-time deadline is Nov 2, 2026 at 8pm PT, with decisions by Dec 11. Late applications are considered without a promised timeline.
- How to apply** ycombinator.com/apply
- Why it fits** The most valuable seed signal available. Early Decision means Amaris can stay at Duke and the team can still lock in YC.

a16z speedrun (SR008)

Andreessen Horowitz · Accelerator / incubator

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

High fit

- What you get** \$500K for 10% on a SAFE upfront, plus \$500K in the next round within 18 months (up to \$1M), and \$5M+ in partner credits.
- Eligibility** Early-stage founders. Not student-specific. In person in SF for the cohort.
- Timing** SR007 ran July 27-Oct 11, 2026. SR008 runs late January-April 2027 in SF. Applications are rolling, reviewed in about 4-6 weeks. A third-party guide reports a priority window of Oct 12-Nov 1; the year is unconfirmed.
- How to apply** speedrun.a16z.com/apply
- Why it fits** AI-friendly and a16z-branded, which helps a seed raise. However, 10% for \$500K is expensive and the cohort requires SF relocation.
- Duke angle** The SR008 priority window opens on 12 Oct 2026. It brings a16z capital plus a demo day full of investors. Speedrun's games/consumer focus is broader than infra, so the fit depends on positioning. Speedrun is a 12-week accelerator with investment of up to \$1M and perks/credits that one article puts at \$5M. The Alpha Fellowship, for students and recent grads, gives a \$20k equity-free grant, eligibility for up to \$250K investment, or placement at a portfolio company. No Duke campus ambassador was found.
- Contacts** **Kenan Saleh**, Posted the a16z speedrun application announcement on X (title not verified), x.com/kenanhsaleh

America's Startup national competition (America250)

America250 · Competition / prize

SimReal qualifies: unclear

open

High fit

- What you get** A \$1M total non-dilutive prize pool. 10 finalist teams get \$25,000 each, and 3 overall winners get another \$25,000 (\$50K total). Includes national mentorship and a live pitch finale. The top 100 entries go to an Investors Council for optional equity investment, and entrants get an NVIDIA Inception invitation.
- Eligibility** US legal residents 13+ who are current undergraduates at an accredited US university, college or trade school. Individuals or teams of up to 5.
- Timing** Opened Aug 17, 2026. Closes Oct 8, 2026 at 7:59pm EDT (4 days away). Requires a written proposal and a short pitch video.
- How to apply** america250.org/americas-startup
- Why it fits** Non-dilutive money that closes this week. It hinges on Amaris being a US legal resident and on whether non-student co-founders can be on the team; if not, Amaris could enter alone.

AWS Activate

Amazon Web Services · Credits / perks

SimReal qualifies: yes

open

Medium fit

- What you get** Up to \$200,000 in credits for eligible startups. The Founders package gives \$1,000 to self-funded startups. No separate student or university path was confirmed in searches.
- Eligibility** Startups. Higher tiers come via provider or accelerator referral.
- Timing** Ongoing.
- How to apply** aws.amazon.com/activate (URL not read)
- Why it fits** Useful compute for RL environments. The student angle is weak; the bigger tiers come through accelerator partners such as Pear, SPC and speedrun.

Google for Startups Cloud Program

SimReal qualifies: yes

open

Medium fit

Google · Credits / perks

What you get \$2,000 for pre-funded startups, up to \$200,000 for seed to Series A, and up to \$350,000 reported for AI-first startups.

Eligibility Startups. No student-specific track was confirmed.

Timing Ongoing.

How to apply Google for Startups Cloud Program site (URL not read)

Why it fits Largest AI-first credit tier, useful for model and environment compute. Not student-specific.

NVIDIA Inception

SimReal qualifies: yes

rolling

Medium fit

NVIDIA · Credits / perks

What you get Free, with no equity or fees. Includes SDKs, Deep Learning Institute credits, hardware and software pricing, and investor and go-to-market support. Third-party sources report up to \$100K in DGX Cloud credits at entry tier and 30% off DGX Cloud. Entrants to America's Startup get an Inception invitation.

Eligibility AI startups globally. Not student-specific.

Timing Rolling.

How to apply NVIDIA Inception site (URL not read)

Why it fits Free and relevant for GPU-heavy RL work. Join now.

Anthropic - Claude for Startups / Claude Campus

SimReal qualifies: likely

open

Medium fit

Anthropic · Credits / perks

What you get Claude for Startups credit tiers: \$5K by direct application, \$25K with a VC or accelerator partner referral, and up to \$100K for startups backed by top-tier VCs. Also priority rate limits. Student angle: Claude Campus ambassadors get a \$3,600 cash stipend, and Builder Clubs share resources such as API credits.

Eligibility Credits need institutional equity funding, a company under 4 years old, and no prior Anthropic credits. Any early-stage founder can apply to the broader program.

Timing Direct applications open since late May 2026.

How to apply claude.com/programs/startups (URL not read)

Why it fits Directly relevant to an LLM post-training company. Ask the lead seed investor for a partner referral code to reach the \$25K-\$100K tiers.

PearX (W27)

Pear VC · Accelerator / incubator

SimReal qualifies: likely

open

Medium fit

- What you get** A 12-week accelerator in SF with \$250K-\$2M investment (terms negotiated by stage). Includes mentorship, hiring support, customer intros and cloud credits. About 20 teams per cohort.
- Eligibility** Pre-seed/seed founders. Teams must relocate to the SF Bay Area.
- Timing** W27 regular deadline: Oct 4 (11:59pm PST), i.e. today, per a third-party listing. S26 ran Feb 10-Apr 12, 2026.
- How to apply** pear.vc/pearx-application
- Why it fits** Strong seed-stage partner with flexible check sizes. The deadline is today and the program needs SF relocation. The Pear Competition (below) is the student route.
- Duke angle** A strong AI and student-founder accelerator, but it skews pre-seed and Bay Area, and there is no Duke channel. PearX, Pear's pre-seed accelerator, fed by Pear Fellows: student scouts on campuses (undergrad, MBA, PhD) who can influence checks of up to \$25k. Pear says about 50% of its portfolio has student-founder origins. No Duke-specific fellow or ambassador was found.

Contrary (Venture Partner program / Contrary Capital)

Contrary · Funding: equity

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

- What you get** Contrary recruits a selective class of student Venture Partners at US and Canadian universities each year to source and back founders. The firm itself invests seed to Series A; a third-party profile cites \$100K-\$2M checks with a \$500K-\$1M sweet spot.
- Eligibility** No published student-only rule. Student founders are typically sourced through campus Venture Partners. Class of 2026 VPs were announced.
- Timing** Rolling investment. Venture Partner applications for 2026 were posted on Contrary's blog.
- How to apply** contrary.com (reach the firm directly or through a Duke Venture Partner if one is listed in the Class of 2026 post)
- Why it fits** Talent-driven seed firm that writes seed-sized checks and fits a technical AI team. Its student VP network is a warm route in.
- Duke angle** Contrary backs young, technical founders. Duke scouts give a direct referral route, though terms are unverified. A warm referral path to Contrary, a venture firm. Its student Venture Partner program recruits 20-30 students a year from top campuses to find early-stage founders. Contrary's published classes include Duke students: Tejas Sukesh (Class of 2026) and Brian Mason (Class of 2025). Earlier classes include Conner Aldrich and Ayush Jain (2024) and Luke Qin and Rachel Ji (2021). Founder-facing check sizes were not verified in this search.
- Contacts**
Eric Tarczynski, Founder, Contrary (founded 2016)
Tejas Sukesh, Contrary Venture Partner, Class of 2026 (Duke) - as listed by Contrary, contrary.com/blog/class-of-2026
Brian Mason, Contrary Venture Partner, Class of 2025 (Duke undergrad, math) - as listed by Contrary, contrary.com/blog/class-of-2025

Emergent Ventures (incl. EV AI)

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

Mercatus Center, George Mason University · Funding: non-dilutive

- What you get** Grants and fellowships led by Tyler Cowen, reported as typically \$10K-\$100K (most around \$50K), plus travel and project grants. EV AI is a dedicated vertical for AI researchers and entrepreneurs.
- Eligibility** Open worldwide, age 13+, with no institutional affiliation required. Covers entrepreneurs, researchers and students.
- Timing** Rolling. The application takes about 30 minutes and decisions can come within days.
- How to apply** www.mercatus.org/announcements/mercatus-center-announces-lau
- Why it fits** Fast, non-dilutive and AI-focused. EV favors individuals with bold ideas, so pitch the founders, e.g. on open RL-environment research.
- Contacts** **Tyler Cowen**, Leads Emergent Ventures (Mercatus Center)

HF0 Residency

SimReal qualifies: likely

rolling

Medium fit

HF0 · Accelerator / incubator

- What you get** A 12-week in-person SF residency with housing and meals, and up to \$1M on an uncapped SAFE for 5%. About 10 teams per cohort.
- Eligibility** Aimed at repeat and high-performing technical founders. AI and deep tech focus. Requires full-time SF residency.
- Timing** Fall 2026 cohort. A third-party listing says rolling applications are accepted until late 2026.
- How to apply** HF0 website (hf0.com; application URL not confirmed)
- Why it fits** Large, founder-friendly terms for AI teams. Very selective, biased to repeat founders, and needs full SF relocation.

SPC Founder Fellowship

SimReal qualifies: likely

upcoming

Medium fit

South Park Commons · Fellowship / program

- What you get** \$400K upfront for 7% on a standard SAFE, plus \$600K guaranteed in the next external round (\$1M total). Includes SPC membership, partner working sessions and \$900K+ in credits (OpenAI, Anthropic, Azure, GCP, AWS and others).
- Eligibility** Pre-idea to early founders. No traction required. Not student-specific.
- Timing** Fall 2026 applications closed Aug 2, 2026. The Spring 2027 cycle has not been announced in the results found.
- How to apply** www.southparkcommons.com/news/f26-founder-fellowship
- Why it fits** Strong seed-equivalent terms and credits. Watch for the next cycle.

AI Grant

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

Medium fit

AI Grant (Nat Friedman & Daniel Gross) · Accelerator / incubator

- What you get** Last published terms: \$250K uncapped SAFE, \$350K in Azure credits and about \$250K in partner credits (Anthropic, OpenAI, Modal and others), about \$850K in total value.
- Eligibility** Seed-stage AI startups. Not student-specific.
- Timing** Batch 4 is listed as closed. No 2026-27 batch found.
- How to apply** new.aigrant.org
- Why it fits** Ideal AI-native terms if a new batch opens. Its continuation is uncertain.

Afore Capital - Founders-in-Residence (incl. FIR University)

Afore Capital · Funding: equity

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

Medium fit

- What you get** Afore runs an 8-week Founders-in-Residence program (cohorts of 5-8; e.g. \$50K and a desk) and a university track, 'FIR University', reported to provide \$20K-\$100K. Fund IV (\$185M, 'Pre-Seed 2.0') writes flexible \$50K-\$2M pre-seed checks.
- Eligibility** The university track is for founders still in college. Pre-seed generally.
- Timing** 2026-27 cohort dates were not found.
- How to apply** Afore Capital website (FIR application URL not found)
- Why it fits** A dedicated pre-seed firm with a college-founder track. It may suit SimReal's pre-seed/seed raise better than its residency.

Rough Draft Ventures

General Catalyst · Funding: equity

SimReal qualifies: likely

unconfirmed

Medium fit

- What you get** Student-run pre-seed fund backed by General Catalyst. A third-party profile says student scouts write \$25,000 checks. Portfolio companies also get coaching from General Catalyst partners and RDV alumni. The fund has backed more than 150 startups.
- Eligibility** Student founders across North American universities (the network spans NA campuses). Whether Duke is a covered campus was not confirmed.
- Timing** Founder pitches are not tied to a published cycle. Student investor recruiting opens each March, with decisions in late April.
- How to apply** roughdraft.vc (pitch through a campus student investor)
- Why it fits** General Catalyst offers a student-founder on-ramp, but the checks are small and RDV historically centers on Boston and Northeast campuses.
- Duke angle** A small check, but a General Catalyst relationship is valuable for a seed raise. Whether the program still runs needs checking. Up to \$25K for student-led teams, plus a community of peers, mentors, alumni and investors. The fund is student-run and powered by General Catalyst, now reframed as GC Venture Fellows. It has backed 150+ startups. Superscout lists the 'Rough Draft Ventures Student Fund' among programs available at Duke, but no named Duke partner was found.

Microsoft Imagine Cup 2027

Microsoft · Competition / prize

SimReal qualifies: unclear

open

Medium fit

- What you get** Global student-startup competition on Microsoft cloud and AI. The 2026 winner received \$150,000 and a mentorship session with Satya Nadella; 2027 prize amounts were not confirmed.
- Eligibility** Teams of up to 4. All members must be enrolled students aged 18+. Launch track: no dilutive funding and at most \$100K non-dilutive. Scale track: at most \$5M combined funding. (Snippet eligibility dates referenced the 2025-26 cycle.)
- Timing** Registration and submission deadline Jan 8, 2027. Regional semifinals in spring 2027 and the world championship in May 2027.
- How to apply** imaginecup.microsoft.com/en-us/category/34
- Why it fits** AI-focused and global. The rule that all members be students excludes graduated co-founders unless only current students enter.

Rice Business Plan Competition 2027

SimReal qualifies: unclear

upcoming

Medium fit

Rice University (Rice Alliance) · Competition / prize

- What you get** More than \$1M in investment and cash prizes expected for 2027. Every startup gets a minimum prize for its placement: no-equity cash, investor prizes, accelerator invitations and in-kind prizes.
- Eligibility** Teams need at least two current students, at least one of them a graduate student. Startups must be student-driven, student-created or student-managed. Must be fundraising within 12 months. Digital enterprise is an eligible sector.
- Timing** Competition Apr 8-10, 2027 in Houston. The 2027 application deadline was not found; the 2026 deadline was Jan 31, 2026.
- How to apply** rbpc.rice.edu/compete/faqs
- Why it fits** The richest student competition, but SimReal needs a current graduate student on the team to qualify.

Neo Residency (startup track)

SimReal qualifies: unclear

unconfirmed

Medium fit

Neo · Accelerator / incubator

- What you get** A third-party guide reports a \$750,000 uncapped SAFE plus participation rights up to 5% ownership.
- Eligibility** Startup teams. North America only, per the same guide.
- Timing** 2026-27 cycle dates were not found.
- How to apply** neo.com/apply
- Why it fits** Large uncapped check from a selective, technical-founder network. It's unclear whether a US/UK team counts as 'North America'.

Neo Scholars

SimReal qualifies: unclear

closed

Medium fit

Neo · Fellowship / program

- What you get** 2026 terms: a \$40,000 equity-free grant to college students, a 3-month SF summer residency, mentorship, recruiting fast-track, and meetups in NY, SF and Boston. Scholars who start a company get guaranteed admission to the Neo Residency.
- Eligibility** Current college students who excel at computer science. North America only.
- Timing** The 2026 cycle opened in May 2026 and closed June 14, 2026. The 2027 cycle is expected in spring 2027 but is not confirmed.
- How to apply** neo.com/apply
- Why it fits** It's non-dilutive money for an individual student and a route into the Neo Residency. It only fits if Amaris has a strong CS profile.
- Duke angle** Residency money is meaningful, but Scholars is an individual CS-student award and Amaris is the COO, so eligibility is uncertain. Neo Scholars: a \$40,000 equity-free grant for college students who excel at computer science, with mentorship, community trips and guaranteed Neo Residency admission if they start a company. Neo Residency: a \$750,000 uncapped SAFE plus participation rights up to 5% ownership. No Duke-specific scout or ambassador was found.

Lower fit · 19

Program	What you get	Why lower fit
GitHub Student Developer Pack GitHub · qualifies: yes	A bundle of free student offers.	Easy to claim through Amaris, but the amounts are tiny next to startup programs.

Microsoft for Startups (Founders Hub) / Azure for Students Microsoft · qualifies: yes	Microsoft for Startups: \$5,000 in Azure credits plus Microsoft 365 and GitHub access (third-party figure).	Modest credits.
1517 Fund (Medici Grants and student/dropout pre-seed) 1517 Fund · qualifies: likely	Medici Project grants give a minimum \$1K stipend with zero equity, zero IP and no future claim.	The grant is tiny.
Modal / Lambda compute credits Modal Labs; Lambda · qualifies: likely	Modal: startup program up to \$50K in credits.	Modal's startup tier is useful for running environments.
Interact Fellowship Interact (501(c)(3)) · qualifies: likely	A two-year fellowship with fully sponsored retreats twice a year in a global community of young technologists.	Founders are the right age, but it's network-only with a social-impact tilt and no capital.
Venture Capital Investment Competition (VCIC) - startup pitch slot UNC Kenan-Flagler Business School · qualifies: likely	Real startups pitch to student 'VC firm' teams and VC judges, go through six due-diligence sessions and negotiate term sheets.	Gives VC-judge exposure and pitch practice near Duke, but no capital.
Wake Forest Elevator Competition Wake Forest University School of Business · qualifies: likely	Historically \$10,000 cash for the first-place Traditional Business winner and \$5,000 for the top Social Entrepreneurship team.	Small prize, and it's unclear whether the competition still runs.
Collegiate Inventors Competition 2027 National Inventors Hall of Fame · qualifies: unclear	Cash prizes up to \$10,000, an all-expenses-paid finalist trip to Washington, D.C., and a patent acceleration certificate.	Invention- and patent-oriented.
Red Bull Basement Red Bull · qualifies: unclear	2026: the World Final winner received \$100,000, \$25,000 in Microsoft Azure credits and mentorship from Red Bull Ventures.	Teams are capped at 2 and US residency is required.
Big Ideas UC Berkeley (Big Ideas@Berkeley) · qualifies: unclear	Not verified: the search budget ran out before this was checked.	Not verified;
OpenAI startup credits OpenAI · qualifies: unclear	Not verified (search budget).	Most accessible through accelerator packages rather than a student path.
Pareto Fellowship / Pareto20 Pareto Holdings · qualifies: unclear	Pareto Holdings (Jon Oringer, Ed Lando) runs a fellowship offering funding, operational support and mentorship.	The young-founder focus fits, but there is no current cycle or published terms.
Prelude / 'Leadership grants' (requested; not identified) not found · qualifies: unclear	No program matching 'Prelude' or 'Leadership grants' for student founders was found in searches.	The founders should confirm which program was meant.
Hult Prize 2027 Hult Prize Foundation · qualifies: no	\$1M seed funding to the winning team.	The recent-graduate founders are not enrolled, and an RL-environments business is a weak fit for the SDG requirement.
KP Fellows (2027) Kleiner Perkins · qualifies: no	A paid summer fellowship working inside a Kleiner Perkins portfolio company in the Bay Area, with a founder speaker series and workshops.	It's an internship for an individual, not company funding, and would pull Amaris away from SimReal for the summer.

Entrepreneur First Entrepreneur First · qualifies: no	A £6,000 talent investment on signing.	EF builds teams from individuals, and SimReal already has a team and product.
Columbia AI Startup Challenge Columbia Business School · qualifies: no	\$40K+ in total prizes for AI-driven startup ideas.	SimReal has no eligible graduate student at these schools;
Thiel Fellowship Thiel Foundation · qualifies: no	\$250,000 over two years (doubled from \$100K in 2024).	Amaris would have to leave Duke, and the Cambridge/LSE graduates already hold degrees, so the team as constituted does not qualify.
New Venture Championship University of Oregon · qualifies: no	Discontinued: the University of Oregon replaced the NVC with the Oregon Innovation Challenge in 2023.	The competition no longer runs.

Contacts · 47

Name	Organization	Email	Profile
Ali Byrd (Duke '95) Described as Managing Partner of Towerview Ventures in an Alumni Ventures Medium profile (date not verified; may be a former role)	Alumni Ventures	not published	medium.com/@alumniventures/meet-ali-byrd-95-managing-partner
Greg Baker (Fuqua '91) Managing Partner, Alumni Ventures (since 2017); runs Towerview Ventures	Alumni Ventures	not published	superscout.co/investor/towerview-ventures
Laura Zabinski Executive Director, American Underground (per 2026 reporting)	American Underground (Durham; Capitol Broadcasting Company)	not published	
Kenan Saleh Posted the a16z speedrun application announcement on X (title not verified)	Andreessen Horowitz	not published	x.com/kenanhsaleh
Alex Bloom CEO, CED (effective 1 Jan 2026)	CED (Council for Entrepreneurial Development)	not published	cednc.org/ced-announces-leadership-transition

Christina Liang Student Investment Partner, Dorm Room Fund Philly & Southeast team; described as a Duke senior (Statistics and French). The interview is undated, so she may have graduated.	Dorm Room Fund (First Round- founded, student- run)	not published	www.boringbusinessnerd.com/post/investing-at-dorm-room-fund-
Madison Jacox Named as part of DRF's professional oversight on terms and diligence (title not verified)	Dorm Room Fund (First Round- founded, student- run)	not published	
Amy Linnane Managing Director, Programs (profile page titled 'Managing Director, Co- Curricular Programs'), Duke I&E; runs all co- curricular programming incl. Melissa & Doug Entrepreneurs	Duke I&E	amy.linnane@duke.edu	entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/amy-linnane
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Jamie N. Jones, PhD Director, Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship; Associate Professor of the Practice of Management, Fuqua (former Executive Director, Fuqua CEI)	Duke I&E	jamie.j@duke.edu	entrepreneurship.duke.edu/profile/jamie-jones
Josh Cohen (MBA '07) Director of MBA Entrepreneurship Programs and Startup Recruiting, Duke I&E (runs Startup Sprint, Innovators' Spark, ELN application process)	Duke I&E	not published	
Melissa C. Smith Senior Program Coordinator, Duke I&E	Duke I&E (sponsored by Melissa Bernstein '87 and Doug Bernstein)	not published	entrepreneurship.duke.edu/staff
Kelley Downey Event contact listed for Duke I&E events (per search snippet of Duke Alumni event page)	Duke Innovation & Entrepreneurship / Duke Alumni Association	not published	alumni.duke.edu/events/duke-ie-nyc-networking-night
Daniel Luo Assistant Director, Duke Capital Partners	Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022)	not published	dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team
Dave Neal Venture Partner, Duke Capital Partners	Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022)	not published	dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team
Dr. Cary Ritter Senior Assistant Director, Duke Capital Partners	Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022)	not published	dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team

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Kurt Schmidt Managing Director, Duke Capital Partners (since 2019)	Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022)	not published	dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/about
Stephanie Seghers Senior Program Coordinator, Duke Capital Partners	Duke University (part of the Office for Translation & Commercialization since 2022)	not published	dukecapitalpartners.duke.edu/departments/operating-team
Emil Runge Executive Director, Launch Chapel Hill (appointed Jan 2025)	Launch Chapel Hill (Town of Chapel Hill / UNC / KPMG partnership)	not published	innovate.unc.edu/emil-runge-joins-launch-chapel-hill-as-new-
Thom Ruhe President & CEO, NC IDEA	NC IDEA (Durham- based private foundation)	not published	kenaninstitute.unc.edu/people/thom-ruhe
Nikhil Mittal Founder & Investment Lead, BlueRidge Ventures	BlueRidge Ventures	not published	decilepro.com/access/blueridgeventures
Austin Armstrong Co-founder, Bullhouse	Bullhouse Ventures	not published	x.com/SocialtyPro
Austin Carroll Co-founder, Bullhouse	Bullhouse Ventures	not published	
Brian Mason Contrary Venture Partner, Class of 2025 (Duke undergrad, math) - as listed by Contrary	Contrary	not published	contrary.com/blog/class-of-2025
Eric Tarczynski Founder, Contrary (founded 2016)	Contrary	not published	

Tejas Sukesh Contrary Venture Partner, Class of 2026 (Duke) - as listed by Contrary	Contrary	not published	contrary.com/blog/class-of-2026
David Hoffman Professor of the Practice, Sanford School; Managing Director, Duke Deep Tech	Duke Sanford School of Public Policy	not published	deeptech.duke.edu/staff
Merritt Cahoon Deep Tech Program Coordinator	Duke Sanford School of Public Policy	not published	deeptech.duke.edu/profile/merritt-cahoon
Ronnie Chatterji Fuqua professor; co-leads Duke Deep Tech; OpenAI chief economist	Duke Sanford School of Public Policy	not published	deeptech.duke.edu/staff
Bryan McGann Clinical Professor of Law; Director, Start-Up Ventures Clinic and Program in Law & Entrepreneurship	Duke University School of Law	bryan.mcgann@duke.edu	law.duke.edu/fac/mcgann
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Nate Goldin Founder & President (as listed on DVG team page; may be outdated)	Duke Venture Group (student-run)	contact@dukeventuregroup.com	www.dukeventuregroup.com/team
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Terrence Ware Co-Founder & Vice President of Finance (as listed on DVG team page)	Duke Venture Group (student- run)	not published	www.dukeventuregroup.com/team
Chris Haberle DukeGEN Seattle chapter co-chair (per his public profile snippet; whether the role is current is not verified)	DukeGEN (alumni- volunteer network, linked to Duke I&E)	not published	www.linkedin.com/in/chrishaberle
Balaji Vasudevan Director of Programs, First Flight Venture Center	First Flight Venture Center (FFVC)	not published	launch.ffvcnc.org/staff-directory
Krista Covey President & CEO, First Flight Venture Center (appointed 2020; current status not reconfirmed in 2026)	First Flight Venture Center (FFVC)	not published	
Tyler Cowen Leads Emergent Ventures (Mercatus Center)	Mercatus Center, George Mason University	not published	
Adria Dunbar Managing Director, Christensen Family Center for Innovation (oversees Duke Product Lab and Pratt Founders)	Pratt School of Engineering	not published	cfci.pratt.duke.edu/people/adria-dunbar-2
Anna Wilson Executive in Residence and Director of Product Lab, CFCI	Pratt School of Engineering	not published	cfci.pratt.duke.edu/people
Steven McClelland Executive Director, Christensen Family Center for Innovation	Pratt School of Engineering	not published	cfci.pratt.duke.edu/people

Howie Rhee Listed as Managing Director, CEI in search results (date unverified; may be outdated)	Duke Fuqua School of Business	not published	
Michael Faber Assistant Director, Duke Innovation Co- Lab	Duke OIT Innovation Co-Lab	not published	colab.duke.edu/about
Hult Prize (general inbox) General contact	Hult Prize Foundation	hello@hultprize.org	
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